

Collaboration-Based Learning Environments Using Augmented Reality

by
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Submitted to the Department of Creative Technologies
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of
DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY IN CREATIVE TECHNOLOGIES
at the
AUCKLAND UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY
November 2025

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ABSTRACT

The developments of the “kinetic theory” of gases made within the last ten years have enabled it to account satisfactorily for many of the laws of gases. The mathematical deductions of Clausius, Maxwell and others, based upon the hypothesis of a gas composed of molecules acting upon each other at impact like perfectly elastic spheres, have furnished expressions for the laws of its elasticity, viscosity, conductivity for heat, diffusive power and other properties. For some of these laws we have experimental data of value in testing the validity of these deductions and assumptions. Next to the elasticity, perhaps the phenomena of the viscosity of gases are best adapted to investigation.¹

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¹Text from Holman (1876): doi:[10.2307/25138434](https://doi.org/10.2307/25138434).

Acknowledgments

Write your acknowledgments here.

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List of Acronyms

VR Virtual Reality

AR Augmented Reality

TEL Technology Enhanced Learning

MR Mixed Reality

CSCW Computer Software for Cooperative Work

CL Collaborative Learning

CoP Community of Practice

VLE Virtual Learning Environment

LMS Learning Management System

Chapter 1

Introduction

In the Netflix animated series *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* (Imaishi et al., 2022), the main character attends courses at a prestigious academy that uses advanced technology to boost education and performance. The students gather in a room with Virtual Reality (VR) headsets and connect to the lesson, which is taught by a holographic (and probably powered by artificial intelligence) tutor. The episode does not show the lesson itself (the entire system fails catastrophically when attacked by malware), but the brief scene highlights the vision many people have of a futuristic classroom, one guided by advanced technology and automatization.

Forsler et al. (2024) propose the term “post-digital classroom” to identify the characteristics and trends in education present in a world beyond the adoption of digital technologies. The purpose of this classroom is not anymore to introduce new technologies to students, but to implement them as an essential factor of the learning process. The post-digital classroom is interconnected, social and global. In this scenario, learning goes beyond the physical classroom because it is based on creating relationships between concepts and developing valuable skills rather than acquiring knowledge. It is also a classroom where information is detached from the physical learning institute, and access to facts and sources is, ideally, immediate, ubiquitous and democratic.

The classroom has also become hybrid. There is little distinction between network-based lessons and the face-to-face spaces associated with schools and universities (Goodyear et al., 2004). Hybrid and blended approaches blur the distinctions between learning in an online setting and learning in a classroom. In both instances, information is at hand in the network, students can easily connect to peers and mentors, distance and time constraints are less meaningful and knowledge is presented in a multimedia format that needs a technological backbone to be created and shared (Rivoltella, 2008; Shank, 2005).

This thesis explores the use of technology in such post-digital classrooms, specifically, AR within the context of mobile computing. Moreover, this research will analyse the creation of effective learning spaces, those places where students can build, personalise and control all the activities they engage with (Gourlay & Oliver, 2016). Learning spaces are interesting tools at the disposal of students because these are spaces that can exist outside the norm of a typical classroom, they are more fluid, less structured and can easily connect to other similar spaces (Nørgård & Hilli, 2022). The proposal of this research is that AR can be used to boost the way students build and interact with their own learning spaces and can also



Figure 1.1: Virtual Classroom in Cyberpunk: Edgerunners

offer educators another option to be integrated in the construction of a lesson that capitalises the characteristics of the aforementioned post-digital classrooms.

Within the field of Technology Enhanced Learning (TEL), AR and related technologies were chosen as a focus of interest because of their intrinsic relationship with space. The initial example scene of Cyberpunk: Edgerunners serves to illustrate the collective idea of what could be achieved in the future with technologies like VR and AR: the possibility of creating an entire new space, suited for the needs of the classroom or the students. It is a space that is shared, in which information and interactions flow between users and that can be controlled at will by students and teachers. In reality, the technology is not quite there yet, especially in terms of fidelity and immersion (Checa & Bustillo, 2020; Hamad & Jia, 2022). What can be explored right now is the creation of interesting synthetic environments that facilitate or allow experiences that are not possible in the common classroom. This process is limited more by the creativity and expertise of the developer rather than by the technology, and therefore can be explored easier and in more detail.

AR, compared to VR, has a more direct relationship with the *real*, physical space and with the context of the user. Instead of an isolated immersion, AR creates a connection with the environment based on image detection, data and visualizations. This natural expression of the technology is where the value of AR can be explored in relation to the creation of innovative learning spaces. The technology not only has interesting capabilities for visualization and interaction, it also allows an easier implementation of shared, social components that can be used to build activities based on cooperative simulations, sharing knowledge and the creation of communities, all crucial elements for the construction of effective learning spaces (Bligh & Crook, 2017).

The research is positioned then in the conjunction of these three fields: Learning spaces, TEL and AR. The guiding goal is to understand how students are using technology to learn,

and how [AR](#) can be used to boost that process. [AR](#) shines at creating immersive experiences that can be shared with others and that consider the physical context of the user. I want to use this collaborative space as an educational tool that takes advantage of the inherent social aspects of learning, building and sharing knowledge.

No modern classroom is free of technology, the simple act of taking notes on a paper already implies a set of technological developments needed to put knowledge into written form. Networking and information technologies are just another set of tools at the disposition of any student. A personal learning space can incorporate different software tools, many of which are now ubiquitous and almost indispensable in any learning activity: text processors, multimedia editing tools, web browsers and document readers, plus any specialised tool that the learning subject requires. But that learning space is also built around more elements, some of them equally indispensable for some students. People need a space to work, access to different amenities, access to textbooks, information and teachers. Some may need a quiet space to concentrate, or, on the contrary, may need access to music, to snacks or to a separate place to periodically take a break. The construction of a learning space involves many different elements, some more technological than others, and its effectiveness is based more on the integration of those elements than anything else (Lu & Churchill, 2013; Reinius et al., 2021). This research aims at identifying how to properly integrate [AR](#) in the construction of a learning space, which is already composed by a complex web of many other objects, tools and circumstances.

As a researcher. I have explored in the past the way different technologies can be used as part of those learning spaces, either with tools for online learning scenarios or using [VR](#) to create a digital space to explore multimedia content (Gil Parga, 2015). This current project can be seen as a way to expand on the work done before, identifying ways to adapt a different technology, to apply lessons learned and to explore new avenues of research. In particular, it is an opportunity to expand from personalized learning environments into social learning spaces, and explore the role of the community in teaching and learning.

It was clear in the work done previously and through some notable literature like Richards (2023) and Long and Ehrmann (2005) that the construction of learning spaces is always mediated by the community around us, even when creating a space as personal as possible. Even nowadays that we live in a post-pandemic world where we seek remote, personalised and secure ways of learning, it has become clear that the social aspect of learning is a crucial element in the equation (Baber, 2021; De Felice et al., 2023). The aim of this research is to delve deeper into the social elements that influence the construction of a learning space, how the students negotiate the process of learning with others and the benefits of collaboration, as well as the challenges it conveys.

This is also a technological enquiry. Having explored [VR](#) in the past, it was clear that this family of technologies offer interesting advantages by using complex visuals, new forms of presenting information and more natural interactions suited for the exploration and experimentation with 3D spaces. These technologies also present curious challenges, especially in the usability front. For instance, the public has not yet developed a strong relation or consistent literacy with the technology (Özgen et al., 2021), which creates accessibility problems. And those technologies that leverage common and accessible platforms, like mobile devices, risk carrying with them problems associated with the excessive and pervasive presence of such technologies (Forsler & Guyard, 2025; Petrucco, 2021).

The following introductory chapter will expand this brief exploration of the context and motivation for the research proposed, outlining the main research goal and the reasoning behind the formulation of the selected research questions. There will be a brief exposition of the methodology followed to build possible answers, the significance of this research and why the answers to the questions proposed can provide important insights about the way we use technology to learn and how we design technological tools for the classroom. It will be followed by a summary of the results obtained and the contributions achieved, as well as the scope and limitations of the work done. The chapter will conclude with a description of the structure of this thesis document.

1.1 Context

AR technologies are positioned somewhere in the middle of the reality-simulation spectrum proposed by Milgram et al. (1995), a model for display technologies used to show digital or physical data in virtual or synthetic realities. The main characteristic of AR in this spectrum is the incorporation of the real world as part of the experience, making use of different image recognition and composition techniques to identify features in the physical space and overlay them with digital information.

Schmalstieg (2016) adds another layer of analysis to the description of AR-like technologies by using the ubiquitous computing spectrum proposed by Weiser (1991). The model positions different implementations of AR depending on the use of more static or more mobile deployment platforms. In one end of the spectrum are applications that can only be used in singular static terminals, while the other side contemplate platform-independent mobile technologies and ubiquitous systems. Figure 1.2 shows examples of this distribution as proposed by the authors.

In this bi-directional spectrum we can find mobile AR as a family of technologies that offer an in-between mixture of virtual and physical elements in which location, place and context are additional inputs used for interaction with the synthetic reality. Any technology in the spectrum will offer a variety of characteristics that align with one or more descriptions at a time. Mixed Reality (MR), for example, are seen as an extension of both VR and AR, offering seamless interaction and connectivity between the real and the simulated world. It is a blurry line that often must be analysed in a case-by-case approach. No matter what label is used to describe a technology, some agreed upon characteristics must be present for it to be categorized as AR, as stated by Azuma (1997):

- A combination of real space and digital information.
- Interaction with the simulation in real time.
- The simulation is done in a 3D space.

With these descriptors it is possible to position the used of the technology in different fields, independent of the labels used to identify it. Based on the themes introduced in the opening statement of the chapter, the goal is to analyse AR as CSCW. For this task, a useful analytical tool is the classification of CSCW technologies proposed by Rodden (1991)

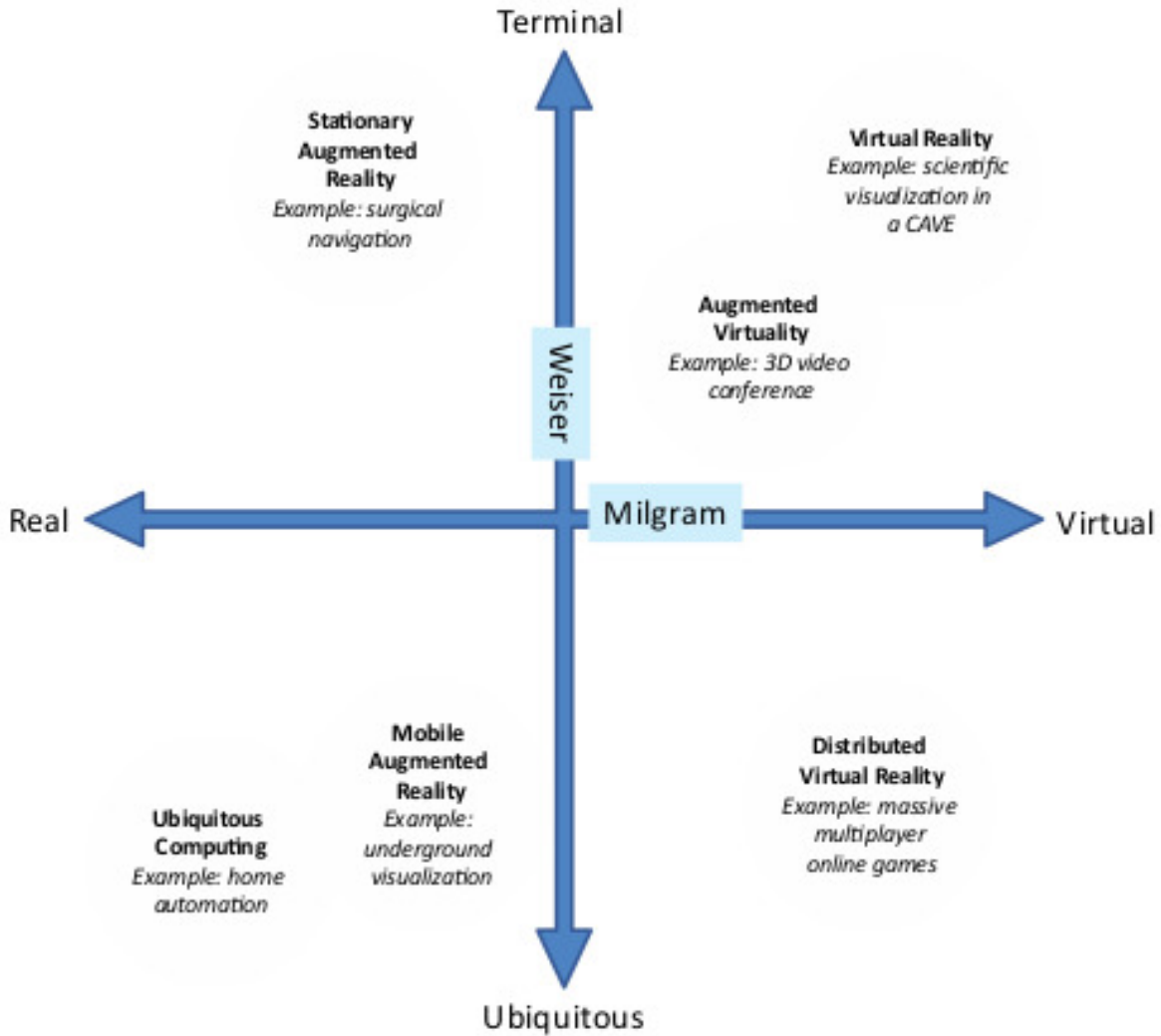


Figure 1.2: AR in the Milgram-Weiser Spectrum (Schmalstieg, 2016).

in terms of the point in time and space where the collaboration is taking place. Figure 1.3 shows examples of different systems that can be found in each quadrant of the classification, which indicate whether the activity is synchronous or asynchronous, remote or co-located.

Complementarily, Kiyokawa et al. (2002) offer two important elements present in a collaborative activity: communication and tasks spaces. In the communication space, people exchange information and can sustain formal and informal conversations. In the task space, the actual cooperative work is done. Those spaces can be unified or separated, and they can be physical, virtual or in a mixed state. Independent of the nature of each individual space, both need to be present for collaboration to succeed.

Based on these classification models, it is possible to define the main field of interest of this research as the use of AR in a mixed task space for face-to-face collaborative learning, which implies synchronous activities in a co-located space. In this setting it should be possible to use the capabilities of AR for visualization and interaction with the physical space to

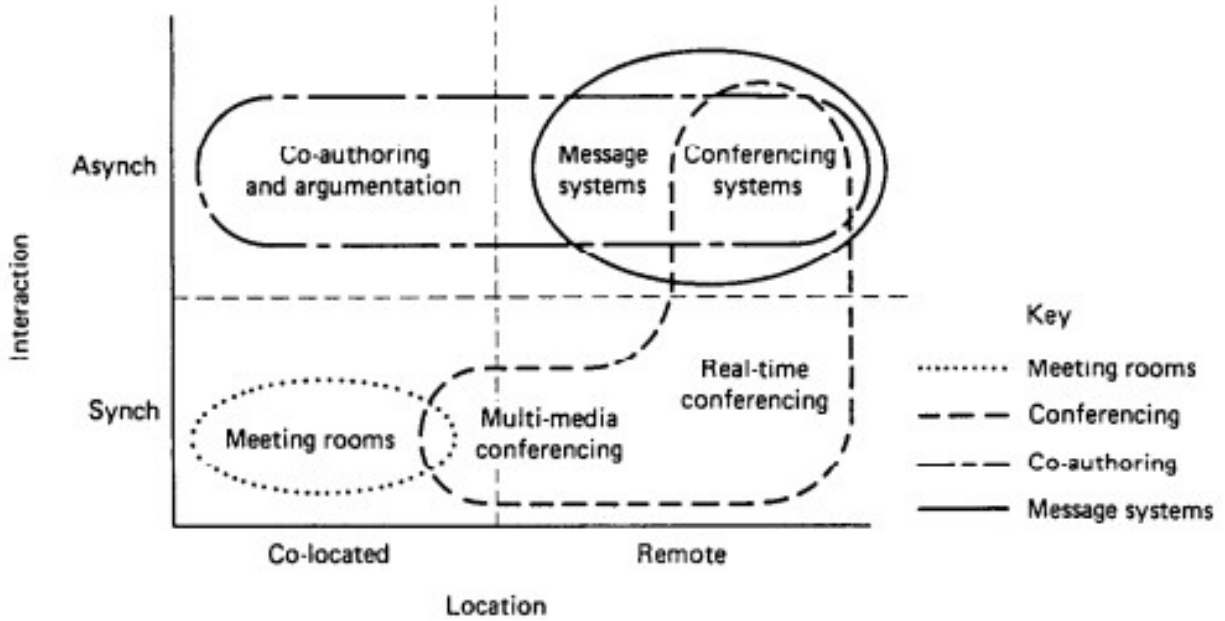


Figure 1.3: Classification of CSCW Systems by Rodden (1991).

augment the collaboration process in terms of:

- Activities related to the communication space, the flow of information and the creation of knowledge in the group.
- The use of the physical space as an asset in the collaborative process.
- Management of the collaborative process itself and the structures that can be created to facilitate effective teamwork and cooperation.
- Guidelines to acquire and refine skills related to teamwork and collaboration.

The main proposal is that the unique characteristics that AR provides in the field of MR are well suited to experiences in co-located collaboration, and that a learning design that is using a collaborative approach can benefit from an AR tool mediating in the communication and tasks spaces of the activity.

The interest in collaborative learning derives from the analysis of the use of AR in education and the tendencies identified in the available literature. It was possible to note that AR is often used as a tool to explore concepts and practices in hands-on approaches that apply previous knowledge in different situations and contexts. Unfortunately, the technology is seldom used in cooperative scenarios, despite the tendency to use mobile platforms for deployment (Gil Parga et al., 2023).

Collaborative learning is a subject rich in discussion. The conversation can focus on the benefits of groupwork in the classroom like promoting different points of view, facilitating complex understanding of a topic and creating the space for an integral development of the student (Smith et al., 1992; Van Wyk & Haffejee, 2017). On the other hand, the challenges associated with collaborative work are also amply explored (Baloche & Brody, 2017; Buchs

et al., 2017; Popov et al., 2012), and there is plenty discussion around issues related to classroom management, inclusivity, effective assessment and good practices.

Many studies have identified and compiled the advantages of using AR and MR as learning tools. For instance, Penn and Ramnarain (2023) offer an analysis of the educational foundations used to design learning interventions. They conclude that most projects converged into constructivist foundations and embodiment theory, opting to create spaces for students to experience and explore the learning subject, with an emphasis on immersion, practice and hands-on interactions. Despite these commonalities, the authors also remarked that most reports do not mention explicitly or do not rationalize the theoretical background of the intervention. They also note that a lot of researchers still hold the idea that introducing a new technology in the classroom is enough to reap its benefits, without caring to build or follow a proper integration plan.

This issue acquires even more relevance now that the mediation of different technologies in the collaboration process has grown due to the Covid-19 pandemic, which forced a quick and often poorly planned implementation of remote learning (Drueke et al., 2021; Nuere et al., 2021). Over time, this prompted the re-design and re-thinking of how to use technology to support the sudden disruption in learning methodologies and approaches (Adi Badiozaman et al., 2020; Fischer et al., 2020). The forced isolation also highlighted the importance of social spaces in the constructions of learning environments, and the need to provide those social interactions even in online spaces (McInnerney & Roberts, 2004; Walas-Trębacz et al., 2025).

The post-pandemic classroom is dealing now with the need to balance the advantages of online spaces with the problems associated with socialization solely mediated by technology, which tends to be asynchronous and impersonal. There is value in the physical space for the learning process (Paechter & Maier, 2010; Petchamé et al., 2021; Thai et al., 2020), and a technology that is able to connect the physical and the digital is worthy of a deeper exploration to identify proper approaches and successful use cases.

The idea is not to oversimplify the presence of digital technologies in the classroom, nor follow a misguided tendency of selling all the benefits of a technology without acknowledging its problems. If the proposal is to identify the effects of a collaborative learning design mediated by AR, it is important to also identify all the problems that derive from this approach, either because of the issues that naturally come from teamworking scenarios in the classroom or the negative behaviours that the excessive use of digital technologies promotes, especially in the specific environment of mobile platforms.

With that context just detailed, it is possible to summarize the goal of this research as: The construction of an AR tool that serves as aid in a collaborative learning setting by helping students to communicate and develop teamworking skills. This can be achieved by means of interactivity, visualization, immersion and augmentation of the physical space.

1.2 Research Structure

The goal of the research can be justified by an abundance of literature showing the elements of AR used in the past to offer distinctive value for learning, and the open opportunities to explore and understand better the development of multi-user AR experiences for collaboration.

The nature of the proposal implies that the research has two main fronts:

- In the *technological* front, the goal is to build a software solution that considers the development challenges of an [AR](#) tool in a multi-user and multi-platform environment, and the specific requirements derived from the learning goals proposed in the educational front.
- In the *educational* front, the goal is to identify, describe and develop a case study based on collaborative learning, and to analyse the behaviours that students develop when learning in a collaborative environment mediated by technology, comparing the use of [AR](#) with other tools or approaches.

1.2.1 Research Questions

The guiding research questions of this project are aimed at obtaining information of what constitutes an effective collaborative learning design using [AR](#). The answers can be stated in terms of learning goals, interaction design and integration plans with the classroom. The questions also seek information about how [AR](#) is creating an effect in the behaviour of the students while using the tool for learning. These behaviours can be related to communication, socialization, planning and engagement with the learning material. The main research question will be stated as follows:

MQ: How does the behaviour of a group of students changes when using an [AR](#) tool designed to aid in the achievement of a learning goal framed in a collaborative learning scenario?

To guide the implementation of the tool through a strong design, a lot of information can be extracted from current literature and from previous projects using similar approaches. Information gathered from real and incremental usage off the system also offers valuable insights in terms of usability, viability and end-user perception. With this in mind, an iterative development process is proposed to facilitate the exploration of ideas regarding interaction design and a proper fit to the learning scenario where the tool is going to be used.

The implementation of the tool alone is insufficient to answer the main question. For this purpose, a case study research methodology is proposed with the objective of identifying and describing a strong context in which collaboration is used for learning and in which the implementation of the [AR](#) tool can be contrasted and compared to other approaches. In this context it is also easier to observe more natural behaviours from the students and the observations will show results closer to how the tool could be used in a real deployment.

It is very important to carefully select a case study that not only offers unique circumstances valuable enough to be analysed in detail but also has the proper learning context to explore the themes of interest of this research project. Although the specific learning field of a prospective case study is not that important, it needs certain characteristics, independently if it is developed through a single activity, a section of a course or through the whole course. The case study must incorporate all the following elements:

- A clear learning goal, either as a whole or as a step to achieve a more complex goal. Assessment activities alone are not enough because the research objectives require the observation of collaborative learning, not the development of a single teamwork activity.
- A collaborative approach to the learning activity. Students must be expected to work in groups to achieve the task, or at least, to have access to a space for collaboration in the development of the activity, even if it is individual in nature.

Ideally, the case study also contemplates the process of learning to collaborate, either as its own learning goal or willing to implement such an objective as a secondary goal. This is not essential, but the current proposal borrows a lot of elements from learning designs about developing collaborative skills. If the selected case study already seeks learning objectives in this venue, then the proposed intervention could offer more value.

The selected case study offers an excellent opportunity, not only to experiment with the proposed thematic of collaboration and technology mediated learning, but because it is also a unique and interesting context in terms of learning design and the opportunities for coordinated teamwork, project development and innovative use of technology.

The Industry Project course of the Built Environments program is a complex scenario that provides students with opportunities to develop industry-level skills through a project-based approach. It presents the opportunity to intervene in the whole course and to use the software solution proposed across different stages of development of the course and different learning objectives, an ideal scenario for varied observations and a rich space for experimentation and discussion.

A set of secondary question can be described that will help to focus the data gathering stages of the research, especially those related to the observations and activities in the context of the case study:

SQ1: What differences in behaviour can be observed between students collaborating using the [AR](#) tool and those that are not?

SQ2: What differences the students report in their perception of the activities done in the course between those using the [AR](#) tool and those who are not?

SQ3: How does the collaboration and communication process changes between students using the [AR](#) tool and those that are not?

SQ4: What differences can be observed in the end results of the course between all the different collaborative approaches observed, especially of those that incorporate the [AR](#) tool?

The focus of the observation process should be in identifying behaviours and processes rather than only differences in the end results, that is, the final assessment of the course project. Relying solely on possible improvements to grades or assessments can be a valid but flawed tool to understand the effects of a technology in the classroom (Dalziel, 1998; Katz et al., 2017). Additionally, the selected case study proposes a complex course to analyse, where several and diverse factors influence the work of the students. Taking this into

consideration is why a positive or negative result does not tell the full story and why is more important to observe the whole learning process, from planning to development, documenting the behaviours developed to fulfil tasks and reach goals. The objective is to identify if the [AR](#) tool proposed is an influence, either positive or negative, and if it provides a more meaningful impact to the learning process as a whole and not only to the end assessments.

Assuming there are actual substantial differences between the students using the [AR](#) tool and those that are not, then it is also important to ask:

SQ5: What elements of a technological intervention using [AR](#) create the most impact in changing the behaviours, perceptions or results of the students?

SQ6: What elements of a multi-user [AR](#) tool creates the most impact in changing the behaviours, perceptions or results of students collaborating and communicating in a learning scenario?

These last questions are meant to provide an evaluation to the decisions taken in the development of the [AR](#) tool, especially the multi-user interactions, and how the tool was integrated to the learning design of the course. It also offers the possibility to highlight elements of the tool that could be polished or reframed in future work.

1.2.2 Scope and Limitations

Using a case study methodology, it is possible to approach the research questions through a qualitative lens, which is better suited for understanding the information gathered about behaviours, relationships developed between students and their subjective perceptions of the course, the activities developed, and the results obtained. All those elements would be hard or contra productive to try and quantify. In this light, it is important to acknowledge the limitations in scope and reach derived by the selected methodologies.

In relation to the software development aspect, it is important to establish the scope of the product as a prototype that explores the ideas of collaboration and multi-user [AR](#). A thorough analysis of the design and architecture of the software was conducted to describe different possible approaches and solutions suited to the context and the needs of the tool, keeping an analytical mindset for all the ramifications and consequences derived from the implementation of a particular idea or design.

In terms of the concrete implementation of the software, the work was undertaken by a sole developer and limited in time and resources related to access to the case study. Most of the design and architectural proposals were tested via mock-ups or wireframe prototypes (Coleman & Goodwin, 2017; Sutipitakwong & Jamsri, 2020) in pseudo-structured test scenarios, aiming primarily for quick feedback and impressions rather than structured data. This allowed constant iteration and exploration of different ideas. The final implementation of the software prioritized showing the most critical use cases and the most relevant interactions with the tool, most of them tailored for specific observation sessions.

This approach had an important influence in the structure of the observation process and the nature of the data gathered, fomenting a more guided use of the tool and a more structured response from the participants rather than the free observation initially intended.

This was an acceptable concession made to facilitate the development process and to give the participants early and consistent access to the tool, albeit in a more incomplete state. This also minimized the disruption to academic work while maximizing the opportunities for meaningful observation in the available time.

There is also an inherent problem in the development of a case study in relation to the applicability of the results, generalization and subjectivity. The Industry Project course was chosen because it fulfilled all the characteristics needed for the research, but convenience aside, the course also provides a unique opportunity to analyse a collaborative learning design in action, with scenarios that could be extrapolated to other similar contexts, but also a unique take on the design of project-based learning and assessment, as well as a complex context for implementation and challenges that had to be tackled, all elements worth of a detailed analysis.

Nonetheless, it is important to identify the limitations of using one sole case study, which can be summarized as issues with the transferability and applicability of the data gathered. Other factors that impact heavily the nature of the data are the overall seniority of the students, which were all close to finish their studies and the lack of a concrete study plan of the course, which focused more on the development of the project as its main teaching instrument, offering just a relatively vague and general set of learning goals.

Chapter 3 will describe in more detail the scope and limitations of the case study, as well as the measures taken to minimize or acknowledge the flaws and restrictions of the chosen framework. For now, these issues can be summarized the main limitations related to focusing the software development into a gradual an iterative progression of a prototype and the validity of the case study in terms of the characteristics needed for the research and the unique value it offers for analysis and discussion.

1.3 Significance and Contributions

The technological environment in which we found ourselves right now evolves rapidly and at large steps. Despite critics of stagnation, the classroom evolves and adapts in response and constantly tries to understand how the available technologies can improve the way we learn (Watters, 2021). It is not always a positive relationship, it is often marred by overselling products and forcing a technological implementation without a plan and a proper consideration of the context and needs of the classroom (Cochrane, 2012; Odunaike et al., 2013). Currently, it is also a field that experiences a lot of social scrutiny as we react to the idea that we have become somewhat addicted to digital content and to the devices used to consume it (Gui & Büchi, 2021; Liu et al., 2022). In a context in which we are banning the use of smartphones in the classrooms and obtaining somewhat positive results because of it (Rahali et al., 2024), why, then, rely on a proposal that fundamentally uses that technology?

As Murray and Perez (2014) establish, exposure to technology does not equal comprehension. In an age in which almost all aspects of life are mediate by digital activities, it is important to create a positive, critical and informed relationship with the technology that we have to use in our daily lives, and that relationship does not develops naturally (Margaryan et al., 2011; Selwyn, 2009). This is a task that can and should be executed in the classroom at different levels of schooling, in different contexts and at appropriate age and field depths.

The classroom is the ideal scenario to create and nourish this relationship in a structured and positive way, yet this is a factor that is seen as lacking in education institutes, especially in middle and high school (Burton et al., 2015; Jeffrey et al., 2011).

This project is an exploration of that philosophy, and an experimentation with a technological design that uses mobile devices in a healthy approach that promotes the development of skills needed today. Although the capacities of AR as a learning tool are evident, this endeavour needs to follow a due process. It is important to properly understand how to use the technology and what elements of the design and implementation process need to be highlighted and worked on to create that intended positive impact. The technology does offer a big opportunity to enhance and reframe the way we communicate and work together, but it also has proven to impose certain challenges that have to be analysed, understood and dealt with.

This document will describe the proposal, design, implementation, observation and analysis activities done in the development of an AR tool for collaborative learning and the test deployment conducted focused on developing skills related to teamwork and effective communication. The development of this research was carried in two interlocked steps. In one hand is the design and implementation of the software WorkshopAR, an AR tool used as a companion in the face-to-face work that was part of the activities proposed for the Industry Project course. Specifically, the software was used during the weekly group sessions of work that the students held for the development of three different assessment milestones in the course-long project.

The development of WorkshopAR consisted in solving two main issues, both related to the technological front of the research. First, there was a design challenge that required identifying the most common interactions performed in an AR environment for cooperative work. Different use cases were identified that were unique for this context and that posed an interesting design challenge, like sharing information, sharing and coordinating resources, managing the status of the team and coordinating the development of a task. A user-centred interaction design process was used to outline solutions for the identified use cases based on important restrictions and particularities of the problem.

This stage was accomplished through a detailed exercise of user-centred design, a process meant to identify ideas and decisions born from the direct interactions of the users with prototypes and mock-ups, a structured process for gathering feedback, integrating the user in the design loop and refining ideas in an iterative process. The results obtained highlighted interesting issues and ideas related to multi-platform interactions, the expectation of users when presented with familiar and unfamiliar controls, complications related to interactions in a 3D space and the integration of the tool in the overall workflow of the students.

The second focus in the development of WorkshopAR was the technical challenge of creating a multi-user, shared AR space. Several commercially available frameworks and APIs were explored, such as the AR Foundation suit provided by the Unity game engine and the Lightship API provided by Niantic. It was possible to extract valuable insights about the current state of the development of AR tools, especially in the field of education, and it was possible to describe the lessons learned while integrating the development process with the educational goals of the course. An effort was made to relate the results obtained to those reported in similar studies by identifying common and divergent results and issues, especially those related to finding the technology distracting and the technical development of the tool

too detached from the role of the educator.

Parallel to the construction of WorkshopAR was the development of the case study and the design of the intervention of the Industry Project course. In the design phase, the course was analysed based on the written material available and on interviews with the teaching staff. This information was used to guide the development of WorkshopAR and to identify the instances in the progression of the course in which the intervention could create more impact without disrupting too much the academic activities of the students. It was also an opportunity to detail and analyse the learning design of the course and to understand the context in which the observations were going to take place.

During the observation phase it was possible to obtain detailed observations of the work done by the students with and without the AR tool, about the development of the project through the conception, design and implementation phases, to adapt elements of the tool to better suit the circumstances of the course and to observe the role of the teaching staff in the development of the course and as part of the usage of the tool. This helped to create a rich record to report in the case study and plenty points of analysis and discussion.

The analysis phase used the recorded information from the observation stage plus all the material that could be recollected from the execution of the course. This material included the written communication given to the students via the official channels of the course, the workshops executed during the semester as material to help in the development of the project and the final products created by the students, such as presentations, reports and designs. The observations were also complemented by a set of semi-structured interviews to the students and the teaching staff. The interviews focused on gathering better records of issues related to the personal perceptions about the use of technology and the collaborative activities of the course.

From the observations obtained and the analysis of the results it was possible to formulate some possible and satisfactory answers to the research questions. The data points to interesting behaviours promoted by the intervention, such as students creating a more structured work process when the tool prompted or encourage them to do it. It was also observed that this enforced structure helped the students with the organization of activities, prompting good practices for communication and the organization of ideas and plans.

But the structure also prompted some unintended behaviours, like a tendency to create a hierarchical organization of the group around the student managing the tool, which was not in tune with the objectives of the course. The app also forced the students to be aware of their phones more than they were planning or willing to do, highlighting a current trend among students of regulating their phone consumption. It was also noticed that the tool was most useful for teams struggling with their organization and offered little value for those already with a clear work plan.

Data and observations also provided a lot of insights related to the design of collaborative interactions in virtual 3D environments, to the relationships of students with their phones and how students use different resources, properly or not, to sort out the difficulties of a learning project. It was evident that the social aspect of the collaborative work resonated the most with the students and with the general satisfaction they reported with the activity, giving more importance to the tools created for them to communicate, express ideas and personalize their experience. The case study also opened an unexpected opportunity to analyse the role of the teaching team in the use of the tool, offering a clear path for future work.

1.4 Document Structure

The purpose of this document is to provide an organized recount of the development of this research work, the theoretical background that supported the proposals given and the methodology followed to gather data, analyse it and build a set of answers for the research questions.

This introduction chapter was meant as a summary of all these elements, highlighting the personal motivations behind the chosen research field and the general reasoning that accompanied the design process, the hypothesized and desired results, as well as the methodological pathway taken. Chapter 2 of this document will describe in detail the literature explored that helped in shaping the research questions and that provided the theoretical basis for the educational methods used as anchors for the software implementation.

Chapter 3 details the methodological framework of the research. It briefly explores the research paradigms picked to guide this project and explains the reasoning for choosing them and their relevance to the learning and technical fields this project is based on. The chapter will also offer a complete explanation of the educational front, detailing all the instruments used in the development of the case study. In the technical front, it details the software development methodology followed, especially the reasoning and procedures used for the interaction design process and the methods used to ensure usability, flexibility, expandability and a general user-centred approach.

The description and analysis of the results have been divided in three chapters. The technological front has been described in Chapter 4, where a detailed explanation of the requirement analysis can be found, including use case scenarios and quality objectives. The chapter also details the most relevant elements of the architectural solutions proposed for the tool. Chapter 5 continues with the description of WorkshopAR, now focused on the implementation process followed. The chapter describes the design phase to the development cycles followed to build the software, the testing strategies used to ensure validity and the feedback received by the users during testing and the observations in the case study.

The case study itself is described in Chapter 6, explaining the context of the Industry Project course, the teaching objectives guiding its design and the points of interest for the intervention using WorkshopAR. The chapter will also provide a narrative description of the observations taken over 20 weeks of development of the course, and a preliminary analysis of the data based on the secondary material extracted, like the written documentation, the work produced by the students and the information gathered from the interviews.

The final analysis is presented in Chapter 7 along with the necessary conclusions gathered from the data and the process described in the previous chapters. The chapter will detail what elements of the development of WorkshopAR and the case study support the proposal of AR as a tool to promote positive learning behaviours and effective collaboration, what important technological hurdles were identified and what surprises were found during the development of the project. The chapter will also offer and outline for future work to address the most outstanding issues derived from the research limitations and the problems encountered during the development of the project.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This project is centred around the concept of Collaborative Learning ([CL](#)): the process of acquiring or creating knowledge as part of a group, and the dynamics that emerge when a team needs to manage participation, the overall success of an activity and the learning objectives that need to be fulfilled (Laal & Ghodsi, [2012](#)). It is also possible to analyse the concept as learning to collaborate, to acquire the skills needed to be an effective team member.

The purpose of this literature review is to find the benefits of adopting a [CL](#) approach in a learning design and the challenges that any educator needs to consider when implementing a strong focus on collaboration. It is also important to understand why collaboration and teamwork are such important skills to develop, why is it so valued in most professional environments and why is there a general feeling that educative institutions are failing in teaching those skills.

This research will approach the field of [CL](#) using the lens of [TEL](#): the use of technologies to support processes or management of teaching and learning (Passey, [2019](#)). Understandably, this is still too wide of a subject, so, a particular focus is set on [AR](#) technologies. The objective will be to understand how [AR](#) can be used in the classroom, and the particularities that it offers in terms of benefits, challenges, common implementations and relevant success stories.

[AR](#) can be a valuable collaborative learning tool based on the unique abilities it possesses. Specifically, the technology excels at incorporating strong visuals into the surroundings of the user(s), which provides an opportunity to design enticing experiences for both learning and collaboration. For this purpose, it is important to identify what collaborative experiences have been created in the past with [AR](#), what learning goals align with the technology and what challenges in design and development can be expected.

This chapter explores these questions and themes across three sections. The first section tackles the topic of collaboration, how it is defined and measured, different implementations in the classroom, perceived benefits, common challenges and lessons learned from previous projects. The second section presents a systematic literature review aimed at identifying the use of [AR](#) as a tool for education, how the technology has evolved, which elements of the technology have derived in success stories, and which have become challenges. The final section will combine both subjects and explore the literature for previous experiences using collaborative [AR](#), both in education and in other fields.

2.1 Collaborative Learning

2.1.1 Collaboration as a Transversal Skill

The subject of CL is wide and can be tackled through different angles. For instance, we can talk about collaboration as an isolated term, and relate it to similar concepts like teamwork, cooperation and intrapersonal skills. In need of a definition, the approach taken by Andriessen and Baker (2020) is very complete. The authors state that “(...) collaboration means developing, in an equal and mutually respectful way, a shared view of a situation”. Is a simple definition that implies two important things. First, collaborators find themselves in equal terms, there is a sense of equality and mutual correspondence. Authoritative or hierarchical relations hardly produce collaborative settings. Second, collaboration goes beyond cooperation, beyond working together to fulfil a goal. Collaboration implies building, through time, a shared view. The group has a shared set of goals, purpose and values. The classical definition of collaboration proposed by Roschelle and Teasley (1995) also complements this idea by stating that cooperation involves the division of labour among participants, of individual responsibility, while collaboration is a coordinated effort to solve the problem. Echoing this distinction between collaboration and similar ideas like cooperation or teamwork, Salmons (2019) states that collaboration is a process that needs to constantly be managed, while teamwork is a more *natural* or *improvised* way of working together when needed.

Andriessen and Baker (2020) later expand all these ideas by stating how collaboration is built through time in three different dimensions. In a personal sense, we collaborate because we gain something from it, or in the worst-case scenario, because we need to do it. Our goals align with those of others, creating a second inter-personal dimension, in which we also care about the relationship we create with others and the social advantages we obtain from the collaboration. Finally, with strong inter-personal interactions, we create a group dynamic, in which decisions are taken beyond the individual level and align with the necessities of the group. This evolution can be fractal, which means that after a strong group has been created, it can be developed in a fourth dimension, an inter-group relationship in which several tight-knitted groups collaborate in a shared purpose within a bigger system.

Now is possible to build an initial definition to be use as conceptual backbone. Collaboration will be understood as: the process in which a group of people build a set of values, shared views and coordinated efforts to fulfil a purpose or reach a goal. This definition considers the most important aspects highlighted previously by other authors: collaboration goes beyond just coordinating tasks because is strongly linked to building relationships and communities, therefore, it is a very social skill. Collaboration is not a single action, is a process that needs time and effort to be constructed. Finally, collaboration is aimed, it needs a purpose or a goal. More important, that goal needs to be shared among the collaborators instead of being imposed. Collaboration can only be developed when all the members of the group find themselves as equals and share the perceived value or the necessity of working towards that aim.

It is possible to add more elements to the definition, creating a wider and stronger framework, if we analyse the concept of collaboration from other perspectives and in different contexts. For instance, collaboration can be viewed as a skill to be developed within the context of professional development and employability.

As stated by Crant (2000), it is common for a workspace to seek in a professional a proper balance between theory and knowledge, that is, the information gathered through practice and experience. This position can be read as employers seeking people that have built a career rather than only have a profession. For employees, it means that they must build that career identity: the right set of skills, experience and personal traits that show value beyond a profession. Additionally, employers seek candidates that can properly response to a variable environment, either due to high pressure or a fast-moving market. Employees must then demonstrate personal adaptability, a willingness to explore, and life-long learning values. Finally, employers seek for the ability to properly construct and use the surrounding social context, the employee needs to build social capital by cultivating abilities in cooperation, networking and teamwork.

This framework shows the importance on adding value to the professional profile, and highlights skills related to adaptability and collaboration as key value pointers. The framework also relates easily to other popular concepts like social intelligence, personal development and problem-solving attitudes, all part of what has been known as transversal skills. The UNESCO defines transversal skills as those that can be used in a wide variety of situations and work settings (UNESCO, 2014) and are valuable for their general applicability and transferability. These skills can be organized in five broad categories:

- Critical and innovative thinking.
- Interpersonal skills.
- Intrapersonal skills.
- Global citizenship.
- Media and information literacy.

To understand better the type of abilities that the previous categories encompass, we can extract some ideas from diverse sources in the literature, a set of studies focused in understanding the work market in different contextual variations of geography, professional field, years of experience and even nature of the job-hunting process (Abir et al., 2024; Boahin & Hofman, 2013; Garst et al., 2019; Huynh et al., 2024; Llorens et al., 2017; Nadarajah, 2021; Ng et al., 2021; Smaldone et al., 2022; Zhang et al., 2024). This sample of literature shows the type of skills most demanded by employers around the world. Although skills that are considered *hard*, or better described as field-specific are understandably diverse, there is almost a complete coordination related to *soft*, transversal skills. These skills are common to all contexts and independent of the region or work field. Figure 2.1 shows a visual distribution of the most common transversal skills sought after in potential candidates, extracted from the studies mentioned above.

Despite being a small sample, the data shows a clear emphasis on relational skills, and it seems to portray the added value of hiring and developing people with high communication abilities, teamwork, good social interactions, and flexibility (Al Asefer & Zainal Abidin, 2021).

Another important sentiment that can be extracted from all the literature mentioned is a perceived discordance between the skills and abilities focused on by high educational

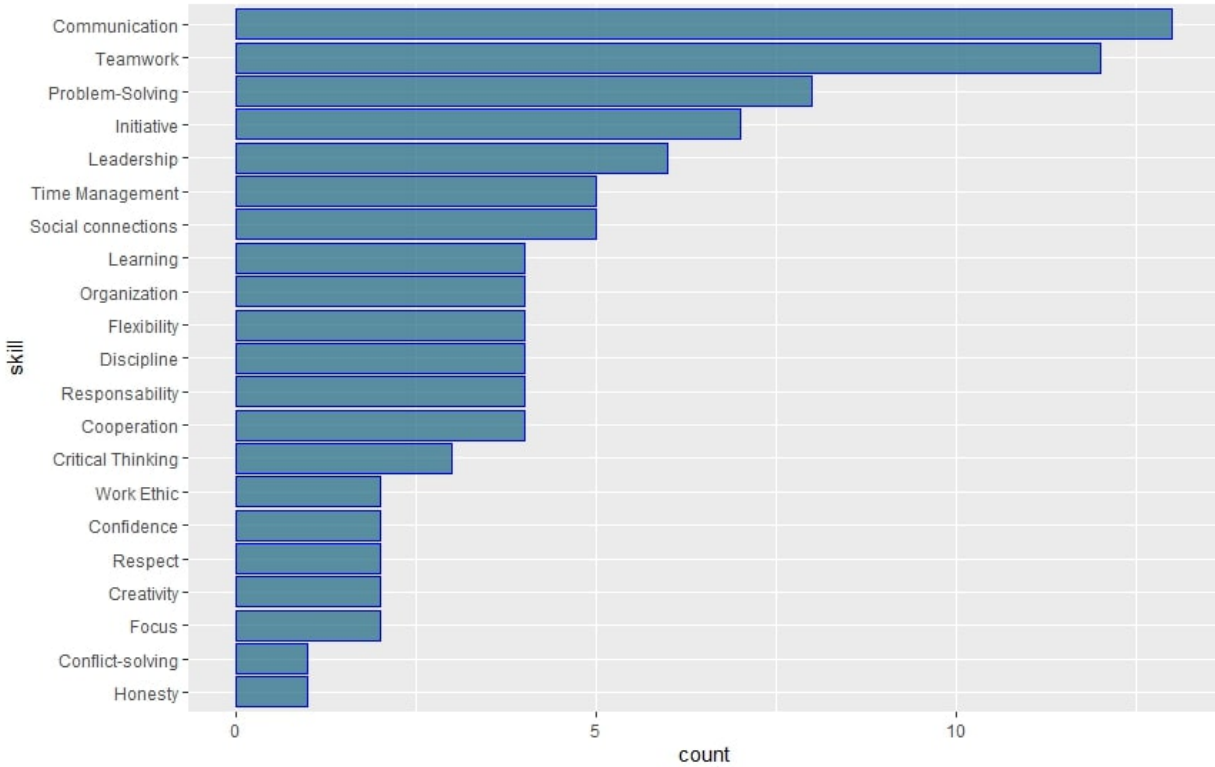


Figure 2.1: Most Common Soft Skills Identified

organisations and those sought after by companies and employees, as identified so far in this section (Damoah et al., 2021; Ng et al., 2021).

Tulgan (2023) identifies specifically three soft skills missing in young workers: professionalism, critical thinking and teamwork. Tulgan argues that this gap is closely related to a generational and technological shift where there is a lower need to develop communication skills because we have offloaded most of our communicational needs into electronical devices (mails, meetings, conversation, social interactions), forgoing the opportunity to develop such skills in person.

Tulgan keeps explaining that in recent years *good old-fashioned* teamwork became an issue for young people, who have developed a different set of values that clash with those of previous generations. Where older generations built a long career as part of a company or institution, newer generations have little to no loyalty to a single employer, and they are more likely to search for better deals. Young professionals find little value in adapting to the ways and stablished institutions of a group when they know very well, they won't be there for too long.

Secondary and tertiary education programs are often seen as the main responsible agents in the development of skills deemed crucial for the general professional life (Kechagias, 2011) and is in this light that modern curricula in almost all disciplines now have a higher emphasis on building those transferable skills (Earl et al., 2021). This is not without problems, and there is a noticeable consensus that teaching such skills is not a trivial task (McCale, 2008). Several factors influence the ability of a curriculum to provide such learning pathways. Most

common problems are related to how little educators are prepared to incorporate those skills in their classrooms (Kemp & Seagraves, 1995), the costs of adapting the curriculum, training the personnel and changing old mindsets to effectively provide the space to create such learning (Chadha, 2006).

Considering these extra contextual elements, it is possible to modify the previous definition of collaboration as follows: Collaboration is the skill to work as part of a group by identifying, building and acting upon a set of values, shared views and coordinated efforts to fulfil a purpose or reach a goal. This modified definition not only states a set of characteristics of what the process of collaborating implies, it frames it as a skill to be executed by each member of a group, and not as something that happens naturally when people gather. It also acknowledges the need to learn and develop such skills.

The theoretical framework around collaborative learning can be expanded by exploring the definition of a second concept, that of Communities of Practice, with the intention of later linking this idea with the general definition of collaboration built so far and the approach proposed by this project to use it as an educational tool.

2.1.2 Communities of Practice

A term proposed by Lave and Wenger (1991), a Community of Practice (CoP) can be defined as a set of mechanisms of situated learning used by communities to transmit knowledge internally, especially to newer members. These communities are formed around a focused domain and were initially used to describe the learning process used in different trades like craftsmanship and health practices. The meaning of the term has been broadening with time and can be applicable to any group that gathers towards a common goal over an extended period, that is, enough time for several generations of members to come and go.

Strongly linked to CoP is the idea of legitimate peripheral participation. This can be defined as the process in which newcomers learn mostly through observation and gradual participation with their senior peers (McDonald & Cater-Steel, 2017). CoP are used to give some structure to the process of informal learning, especially the type of learning found outside of academy, and which is more linked to professional practice, personal development and the relationships forged in the day-to-day activities with peers and a community in general.

A healthy CoP is one that is generated naturally due to the interaction of a community around a specific domain. It is different from a task force or team of people gathered around a goal or a problem in the sense that the general objective of a CoP is more undefined in terms of time, is focused more on the practice rather than the goal or product itself and is constituted by a social community rather than by just a collaborating team of people. These are the three fundamental elements that define a CoP: a domain, a community and a established practice, as described in Figure 2.2.

The domain is the knowledge base in which the community chooses to work because it offers value or just interest in general. New members come voluntarily and interact with elder members gaining experience in the practice, with the expectation of eventually gaining mastery.

The community is a group of people that can be driven by complex social dynamics. The community will create norms, stratifications and behaviours over time. The community is

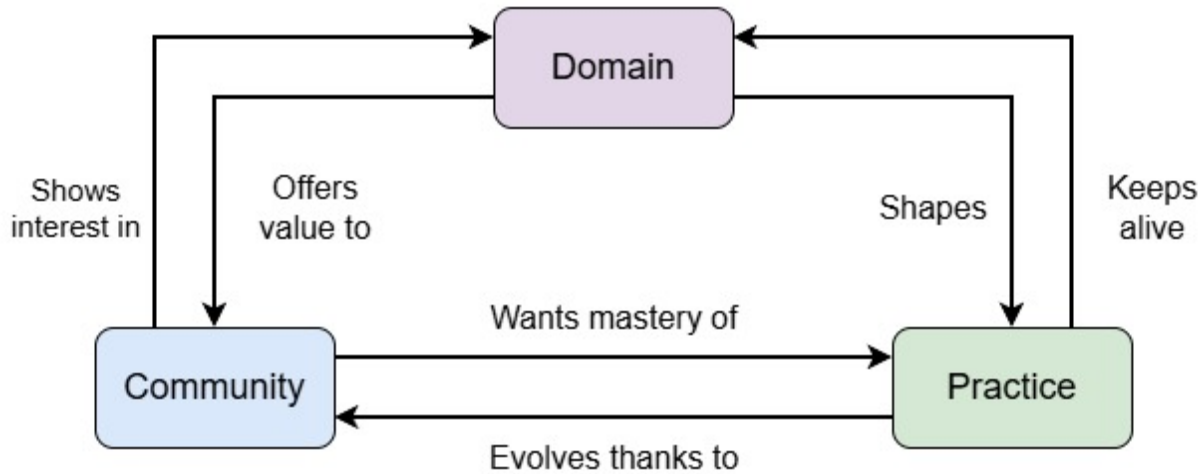


Figure 2.2: Elements of a Community of Practice

expected to be in a constant flux of members and to evolve with time, in terms of social interactions and the relationship it has with the domain.

The practice is an integrated set of activities and knowledge executed and transmitted by the community to create mastery over them. Some CoP focus more on nurturing members into the mastery of the practice, while other focus more on the transmission and preservation of the knowledge generated, as noted by Klein et al. (2005).

CoP have shown to be the cornerstones in the development of informal and social learning, leadership development and organizational change (Anderson & McCune, 2013). Often, high indexes of performance and employee satisfaction are present when a CoP has been identified and nurtured within the informal structure of an organization (Blackmore et al., 2010). Also, they have proven to be valuable integration, communication, and identity reinforcement tools in communities with a high degree of disparity or diversity among members (Hildreth & Kimble, 2004).

A particular emphasis in the idea of nurturing a CoP is important. A community can perish due to lack of proper nourishment or caused by artificial intervention. Previously it was noted that it is not possible to force the creation of a CoP, new members must voluntarily engage in legitimate ways with the practice. But even when a community develops and grows in members, and its value is acknowledged and sought after, forced practices that run in contradiction with the spirit of a CoP can end up killing it. Authors like Ardichvili et al. (2003) and Brown and Duguid (1991) have analysed the lifecycles of successful and failed CoP inside the organizational practice of many and varied industries, from insurance brokers to high education institutes. Of all the key factors identified in the failure or disappearance of a CoP, it is useful to highlight the following ones:

- Not allowing enough time for members of the community to form relationships and sustain them. This can be due to frequent administrative reorganization or the prevalence of temporary or part-time staff.
- A culture of tight management, where every aspect of the practice is highly standardized

and supervised, and there is no possibility for a natural development of the practice due to the relationships formed in the community.

- A culture of highly individualized work, either due to the very nature of the practice or because of other factors, like a very competitive environment. This inhibits collaboration and discourages collective engagement.
- Practices with extreme time or performance pressures, which leaves little time to develop a collective or communicative environment.
- Spatially fragmented work, so that there is no opportunity to establish a relationship, or because there is not a common, unsupervised space for the community to gather.
- Communication and activities are heavily mediated by technology or even other people. This makes interactions (arguably) less immediate and intense, therefore, lacking importance.

So far, all the elements that have been illustrated paint the concept of a [CoP](#) as a natural-occurring social structure formed around the need of preserving, communicating and nourishing knowledge within a well established community. It is a manifestation of informal education that thrives and offers the best results when acknowledged at an organizational level but not tampered with (Brown & Duguid, [1991](#)), and when given enough resources to grow and evolve (Klein & Connell, [2008](#)).

Given the importance of naturality and informality within the definition of a [CoP](#), it is possible to see how these fundamental elements can be at odds with the expectations and common practices found in more traditional and institutionalized education, where learning is more structured, participation is hardly voluntary and collaborative processes are more task-focused rather than long-term approaches to the practice. These issues will be acknowledged in the following section.

2.1.3 Communities of Practice and Education

A common image of what could be considered *collaborative learning* in a classroom setting can be of a group of students working together to fulfil an assignment, say, a presentation on an assigned topic. Although it is possible to define this group of students as a community that came together with the goal of learning something, it fails several other criteria needed to be called a [CoP](#).

In first instance, the example scenario breaks the idea of *natural occurrence*. The group was not formed by the voluntary interest of the students to engage with the domain, but as a necessity to complete a particular task. Also, it would not be uncommon for the composition of the group to be a forced assignment, either by chance or by the designation of the teacher, which would not constitute a community formed by the natural connection of its members.

The community itself also lacks perpetuity because its existence is linked only to the fulfilment of the task. Although the students can benefit from the work done alongside their peers, the knowledge and mastery acquired benefit only the immediate members of the group, they will not be transmitted to other members, nor is it expected for the group to grow and evolve.

Despite all these shortcomings, there are advantages in using the CoP approach in this scenario. For example, it can be argued that the activity does offer a genuine peripheral participation with the practice, allowing the students to engage with elements of the domain and work towards mastery. This engagement is achieved more through structured lessons rather than by informal observation of the actual practice, but it still offers the general idea of a gradual and guided approach.

To properly identify the community formed around this practice more elements need to be added to the analysis. In that way, the natural structures that are normally present in a CoP will get clearer. By including the teacher in the community, it is possible to identify expected elements like eldership and meaningful learning-focused forms of communication. By considering all the groups formed by all the students in the classroom, not only the initial single group, it is easier to see the opportunities for more meaningful relationships to be formed between peers, for more variations on the ways they approach the task or for more opportunities for that practice to evolve. The same results can be obtained by extending the timeframe in which we are analysing this activity, and considering not only the current cohort of students, but also all previous and future groups that participated and will participate in the activity. It is possible to keep adding more elements to the scenario, like all the teachers that have overseen this course and all the courses that are part of the same department, for instance. This exercise exemplifies that, although there are fundamental problems in the definition of a CoP in the scenario of institutionalized education, a lot of the core elements can be found with interesting variations.

A study group could be a better example of using a CoP as a useful framework of analysis in this context. In these circumstances, it is common for the group to form naturally, as a voluntary activity surging from the necessity of mastering a subject (for an upcoming test, i.e.) or because the students have identified that having the support of other peers helps them achieve better academical results. In any case, the core purpose of the group is learning and practice, rather than the fulfilment of tasks. The relationships between the participants extend beyond organizational roles and the focus lays on the transmission and collaborative generation of knowledge and expertise.

Cremers et al. (2008) analyse the formation of CoP in higher education in a similar way to the one proposed before. They argue that knowledge sharing and knowledge creation require a different set of skills than those needed for groupwork. A CoP becomes an ideal tool to promote those skills and to prepare students for the type of informal learning processes they will find later in life. Yet, forcing students to create a CoP or creating a lesson around the use of a CoP goes in contradiction to the spirit of the term, which is meant to be voluntary and informal. Giving continuation to the initial example, a study group works the best when the students themselves want to be part of it, and it is because they recognize that they need the help of their peers or because the collaborative activity is beneficial, not necessarily because it is part of a lesson proposed by the teacher, or even worse, because it is a mandatory part of an assessment.

It is then necessary to come back to the idea that a CoP must be cultivated rather than created (Wenger et al., 2002). When designing a lesson, a course or a curriculum, several steps can be taken to promote the natural formation of CoP. Klein and Connell (2008) propose a series of principles used to nourish CoP that can be followed to create proper spaces for them to form naturally. For example, students should be allowed to propose and develop

their own activities, with possibilities to grow on their own and to have active channels of communications with external sources, like teaching staff. It is also important for students to have access to physical spaces to develop such activities, encouraging both public and private work. The teaching staff should also be aware that they are stakeholders in this scenario, being an integral part of the *value* that the students create by engaging with the CoP and the natural *rhythm* the creation of this CoP follow related to the activities proposed by teachers, like due dates and exam weeks.

Cremers et al. (2008) go a step beyond and propose that students should actively learn to be part of a CoP, arguing that it is no different to learning the proper skills to be a good team member. Speaking in terms of learning outcomes, they establish that a student should be able to:

- Reflect on the state of the practice and the necessities for future development and evolution.
- Be able to communicate and make explicit the results of their engagement with the practice.
- Be able to use the resources of the community in their engagement of the practice.
- Construct, organize and create new knowledge in collaboration with the community.

Rather than asking students to create a real CoP or forcing their participation in one, there is more value in giving the students the tools to understand the dynamics found in a CoP and the proper way of participating and creating value in one. Keay and O'Mahony (2016) echoes this idea by arguing that the significance of a CoP lies in the process rather than in the product. The process of interacting and collaborating with the community has an inherent value, even if a CoP is not properly constructed, and that is what a student needs to learn and be exposed to.

It has been noted by several authors that the dynamics found in a CoP can also emerge and be fostered in online environments, such as Riverin and Stacey (2008) in the perspective of the students and Kirschner and Lai (2007) in the perspective of the educators. These online CoP can emerge and be effective provided that similar circumstances allow the natural growth of the community, like an open participation and clear opportunities for mentorship. CoP for online environments have been found to boost participation and engagement in students, especially young ones (Thomas, 2005), which reinforced the idea that the creation of a community is crucial for a successful remote learning experience (Archambault et al., 2022; Swan, 2002), which circles back to the importance and usefulness of collaboration as a learning tool.

In summary, a Community of Practice is an analytical framework better used to understand processes of informal learning strongly linked to the social dynamics of its members (Wenger, 1998). These characteristics often find themselves at odds with the more formal and structured forms of learning in educational institutions but still offer valuable insights and working tools when analysing the activities done by students outside the structure of a classroom, and more related to their practice of being students.

As discussed in Section 2.1.1, collaboration is as skill that needs to be developed, not only because it is a well sought-after *soft skill*, but also because it is an integral component of professional development, community integration and life-long learning skills. As students, we become part of a particular Community of Practice that works around the development of useful skills for learning and academical success. The development of these skills is, at risk of proposing a circular definition, a collaborative process, one that is hard and unproductive to create in a forced or artificial manner, but than can be promoted and grown given the proper resources and the correct nourishment.

2.1.4 Learning Teamwork and Collaboration

A lot of literature can be found that try to create a model of how individuals come together as a group to achieve a goal, identifying all the factors (internal, external, personal, emotional or circumstantial) that contribute to the success and failure of a group. For example, Bion (2003) offers a good explanation of the Tavistock approach, a systematic view of the psychological dynamics present in the conformation and life cycle of a group. This model identifies important structures that appear inside a group like authority figures, responsibilities, boundaries (both internal and external), crisis responses and organizational structures. Participants form and engage with these elements even if they do not properly identify and name them.

A group can also be analysed in terms of the behaviours adopted by its members. Bales (1970) categorizes the possible interactions performed by team members into task-oriented and emotional. The latter category can be charged with a positive, neutral or negative tone. These behaviours can be expressed through every form of communication that the group uses, including non-verbal cues like body posture or voice tone.

Following the behavioural line of thought, Knowles (1982) identifies some factors that strongly influence the unique identity that a group develops through time. Factors like time constraints, physical environments, group size, composition, overall goals, patterns of participation, communication tools and the set of norms, procedures and structures that emerged within the group.

All these elements create a valuable toolbox of concepts that are useful to systematically describe the work, behaviours, relationships and experiences of a group. They create an essential common language that describes problems within a group, propose solutions, set goals or creates awareness of the elements that are expected to emerge or the issues that must be addressed when working with others. These elements shouldn't be the focus in the process of teaching collaboration but do offer a solid structure in the design of a solution.

A better approach to the learning process is to understand why we collaborate, not only in terms of the employability necessity that has been exposed previously, but also in terms of finding value in teamworking, even if the approach was not voluntary or when collaboration becomes a necessity rather than a goal. When framing our group relationships through the idea of creating value for the group and extracting value for ourselves, we can focus on identifying all the aspects that develop an effective collaboration, those that create more value (DAWSON, 2017; Wagner et al., 2010). When identified, these factors can be replicated and taught in controlled and varied scenarios so that students become aware of their value, build their own experiences of success and failure in a safe space and gain proficiency in identifying and replicating those same elements by themselves.

Hibbert and Huxham (2005) use the terms collaborative advantage and collaborative inertia. We navigate towards collaboration because we find a tangible advantage in the process (for example, the task cannot be accomplished by an individual). But even with a concrete advantage, no interaction can be initiated if the initial collaborative inertia is not surmounted. This inertia is defined as all the barriers that impede collaboration, things like:

- A personal unwillingness to seek input or to learn from others.
- Hoarding expertise, defined as an unwillingness to help others, share knowledge or skills.
- Inability, due to lack of skills or resources, to transfer knowledge.
- An impulse to compete.

The role of competition, especially in academic settings, has an interesting antagonistic nature to collaboration. A dose of competitive elements in an academical setting creates interesting results in terms of providing motivation and building a sense of belonging (Bergin, 2016). Yet, it has also been analysed that focusing too much on the competitive aspects of schooling can derive in undermining the intrinsic value of learning (Tauer & Harackiewicz, 2004) or creating an environment in which the competition is more important than the learning outcomes (Kowalski & Christensen, 2019). This pervasive sense of competition in schools is one of the main issues behind the generalize reticence of students to participate in collaborative activities, which can also derive in lack of motivation, loss of focus and general disinterest in the goal of the collaborative activity itself (Driscoll, 2025; Kloepper, 2023).

One of the first steps to implement a framework for learning how to collaborate is to identify which of these barriers are at play and provide tools to deal with them and not just hope for people to continuously stumble into these problems and finding solutions by chance or by trial and error. Salmons (2019) provides an extensive analysis of what collaboration is and how to create an environment that teaches and promotes it. One first effort is to acknowledge and identify different types of collaboration, defined by the overall achievements gained and the value obtained by participating in the collaboration. Salmons identifies these four degrees of collaboration:

- *Co-creation*: Collaborative generation of new knowledge, processes or products.
- *Acquisition*: A team effort to acquire or develop new skills or knowledge that none of the participants had prior to the collaboration.
- *Transfer*: Sharing expertise or knowledge between the members of a group to create a wider and more complex pool of knowledge or skills.
- *Exchange*: Sharing physical and human resources to fulfil a goal that could not be achieved individually.

Salmons also offers a complementary approach to the idea of value generation explored in other literature. She establishes that before any form of valuable collaboration can be generated, it is important to reinforce two cohesive elements of any group trying to work

together: trust and communication. These building blocks are the main forces used to create meaningful connections inside the group, which in the future leads to the creation and perception of value.

Trust refers to feeling comfortable while working towards and sharing goals with other people. *Trust* can also be seen as a form of social capital (Addison & Teixeira, 2020) that determines how willing is someone to cooperate with others and accept relationships and situations of dependence (Zand, 1972), risk, uncertainty (Frederiksen, 2014) and hope for mutual benefit (Kramer & Tyler, 1996). On the other hand, a lack of trust can be evidenced through feelings of dread and exhaustion within the group, forcing collaboration only when strictly necessary. Vangen and Huxham (2012) also identify the ability to create a safe environment for all the members of the group as an exercise of trust, where the social risks associated with dealing with other people are negated or mitigated, so it is possible to concentrate in creating results consistently. A group that can create trust within is more resilient to external issues, to errors and to conflicts. It also shows a better capability for self-reflection and faster course correction (Shinya et al., 2016). A high level of trust is also correlated to safe environments for innovation and risk-taking (Bichard, 2005).

The second building block proposed by Salmons is to develop proper channels, skills and habits of communication. The author describes two types of communications in a collaborative setting:

- *Dialogue*: Defined as formal and structural communication best used for planning and coordination. It is also the best form for establishing rules and initiating collaboration itself in new groups.
- *Conversation*: Defined as informal and loose communication used to create relationships. It is also the best tool to build and convey trust in the group.

Proper and structured dialogue is also the main venue for students to learn and practice collaboration. Essential aspects of teamwork can be evidenced and assessed through activities guided by dialogue that students engage with. The structuredness of dialogue also helps in creating activities and resources that show collaborative skills that students can develop and provide evidence of, such as:

- Proper use of interpersonal skills.
- Understanding of the task or project.
- Work design.
- Task allocation.
- Quality assurance.
- Coordination.
- Communication of progress.
- Accountability.

- Conflict resolution.
- Decision making.

With these elements is possible to create a roadmap that guides a lesson, a project or an assessment in which collaboration is an important learning goal.

Through dialogue it is also possible to create a third communication skill fundamental for a successful collaboration, *review*. This is defined as a process of self-reflection focused on the work or progress done by the group. A review process can also be structured, facilitating teaching and assessment activities, and can be mapped, as shown previously with the main indicators of dialogue, to key aspects like:

- Ask and give support.
- Analyse and challenge other's contributions.
- Analysis and incorporate feedback.
- Encourage peers.
- Monitoring peers.

Other authors like Keay (2006) proposes similar criteria for proper collaboration in terms of trust, respect and effective communication. Additionally. example implementations like the one showed by Lingard and Barkataki (2012) highlight some other success factors like developing a sense of self-organization, inclusivity and responsibility. Marasi (2019) proposed a series of activities that highlight important attitudes and approaches for healthy teamwork like listening before responding, being affirmative of other's ideas and being mindful of nonverbal communication. Davis and Ulseth (2013) and Asrori and Tjalla (2020) iterated over these concepts and proposed different frameworks, activities and observations that identified other important ideas like accountability, feedback, ownership, empathy and long-life learning.

Table 2.1 serves as a general summary of the concepts and ideas explored throughout this section and shows a map that links fundamental criteria of effective collaboration with activities and behaviours that acts as helpful evidence of those fundamental elements in the work and interactions of a group of students. This map provides a structured tool that will be used as an initial standpoint for all the educational and technological developments of this research project that have collaboration as the main learning goal. They are also a useful tool to frame the analysis of the work done by student in the development of the case study and to describe the learning design proposed by the Industry Project course.

2.1.5 Conclusion: Approach to Collaborative Learning

At this point this literature review has explored some of the tools needed to properly characterize the benefits and challenges around collaborative learning. From the definition built in section 2.1.1, collaboration is a skill developed by students to achieve a common goal through a shared set of values, views and efforts. The common goal here is learning.

Criteria	Evidence	Examples in Literature
A shared common goal	Work Design	Fisher (2014) and Kernaghan & Cooke (1990)
	Goal and task ownership	Kropp & Dodd (2024) and Sohmen (2015)
	Co-creation and acquisition of knowledge	Drejer & Jørgensen (2005) and Salmons (2019)
Willingness to collaborate	Inclusion of all members	Keay (2006) and Zubiri-Esnaola et al. (2020)
	Affirmation of all ideas	Marasi (2019)
	Group bonding and empathy	Blanco et al. (2017) and Widayati et al. (2022)
	Share knowledge and resources	Nissen et al. (2014)
Proper management	Task allocation	Hirshfield & Chachra (2015)
	Self-Organization of the group	Keay (2006)
	Communication patterns	Amponsah (2003) and Jahng et al. (2010)
	Flexible structure	Gross (1997) and Jacobs (2015)

Table 2.1: Evidence Factors and Assessment of Collaborative Work

Section 2.1.2 introduces the concept of a Community of Practice and all the positive implications of using such framework in terms of understanding the motivations that drive the people partaking in collaborative work. In a CoP there is a feedback loop between participants and the constantly evolving field of work in which they are immersed. A proper and healthy CoP has an antagonistic view of the type of work normally found in a classroom, with little agency from the students and a practice limited in time and scope to the fulfilment of a task.

Nonetheless, exposing students to the general dynamics of a CoP has value, especially considering both the ubiquity and the transparency of such dynamics in the workspace. It is also valuable to refocus the approaches used for a CoP in the classroom not as a fancy synonym to teamwork or classroom group work, but as a tool to analyse how students in general approach their learning tasks. This can be achieved by identifying a whole classroom (or cohort, or course, or department, etc.) as the community. The practice is not a task or a project, but the process of learning in the specific domain. In the proper environment, students develop tools to manage their learning and the relationships that naturally grow between peers and teachers.

Finally, in section 2.1.4, the information found on current literature was used to establish a set of criteria and evidence-base assessments that can guide a pedagogical design based on collaboration as a learning tool or that focuses on collaboration as the learning goal.

Collaborative learning can become a useful tool for the classroom based on the approach taken to encourage and manage teamwork. While trying to collaborate in the fulfilment of a task, students learn how to summarize and share information, co-construct ideas through

dialog and debate, and improve retention and comprehension through the simple action of raising questions and answering them (Andrews & Rapp, 2015). Activities requiring teamwork also help in the development of critical thinking abilities (Zandvakili et al., 2019) and prepare students for a realistic work environment (Chowdhury et al., 2002).

Collaborative activities help students create a better understanding of the task at hand. Salmons (2019) uses the concept of *workflow*, where students must discuss, design and implement a concrete plan that help them achieve their objectives. Even if this plan involves a simple coordination of consecutive or parallel tasks, or a more complex synergetic form of work, the process of coming with ideas and solutions to tackle the needs of the task creates a stronger involvement with the team and the project. Similarly, coordinating work efforts develops proficiency in communication, especially in developing literacy (and digital literacy) around tools for remote communication, file sharing, document cocreation and asynchronous work coordination (Lo, 2009; Murphy & Cifuentes, 2001).

Collaborative activities are also often associated with creativity and transformative learning by providing the proper conditions to bring ideas together, compare solutions and expose different viewpoints (Peppler & Solomou, 2011; Turnbull et al., 2010). Rubbing ideas together offers extra value to the generation of knowledge by also providing the circumstances to make connections around that knowledge and challenging preconceptions or stereotypes (César & Santos, 2006; Eden & Ayeeni, 2024).

But working in a collaborative setting is not without its challenges and hurdles. Just the act of being in a group is not enough to boost the educative process of the students. If the proper tools are not provided and major barriers are not acknowledged, the situation can flip around, and teamwork can become more of a liaison than a boost.

One of the most common issues is power imbalance, a natural occurrence whenever there is a group of people gathered towards a common goal (Essabbar, 2015). Elements related to gender, social status or economic issues, among other things, are always factors to consider when using teamwork as the main driver of a lesson. When a strong imbalance is present in a group, it can be evidenced is several behaviours and outcomes that could hinder the learning process of the students. Different authors have identified some of these patterns in different contexts, like inconsistent exposition to the learning material, coarse relationships forming between students, lack of agency in work distribution (Griffin et al., 2015), stress, downgrading performance and lack of response to feedback (Van Der Vegt et al., 2010).

Educators need to develop the necessary foresight to acknowledge these difficulties and provide the students the tools to solve them. In general, it has been shown that self-reflection, an effective mediation and clear communication methods work the best when dealing with issues of imbalance. A closely related analysis in search of solutions for this situation is related to academic imbalance, especially when it affects the educator and different expectations in terms of performance and achievements formed for each group member. A lot of studies have worked on strategies to identify these discrepancies and how to work around them, proposing tools like peer-assessment (Rezaei, 2018) participative rotation, close time management (Davies, 2009) and smart grouping (Akhrif et al., 2019; Wang, 2009). The important note is to be aware that issues with academic imbalance are common, and that there are several tools to manage them and even take advantage of them.

Management chaos is also always associated with groupwork, not only from the point of view of the students but also from the educators. It is expected that students will have

problems with managing elements associated with groupwork, like distribution of work, problem solving and self-reflection. It is also expected that the students will find the educational material needed to learn how to cope with those management issues in the educators or the course itself. Nonetheless, it is surprising how often it is expected that students collaborate without giving them the tools to learn how to do it. Bruffee (1973) provides an interesting record of his experiences implementing a collaborative approach with his students, and a lot of information can be extracted from this case study in terms of the work needed to set-up and manage the tools, environment and mindset that allows a proper collaboration. This extra management time is noted to be present both for the students and for the educator.

Jaques and Salmon (2007) also identify other behaviours that arise when students don't feel comfortable working in groups. Poor participation and general distress can be associated with cultural differences and expectations around how to behave in a group, or, as Biggs et al. (2022) also noted, around personalities that inhibit themselves easily when in a *formal* or *high stakes* form of participation. Other issues reported by students themselves are related to frustration around low performance groups, previous bad experiences or having to deal with personalities that are too outgoing, and which completely dominate the whole group in detriment of other students.

The myriads of advantages present in building a learning experience around collaboration can be attained when the proper tools and the proper environment is provided to the students. It is also important to acknowledge and provide pathways to deal with inevitable issues around conflicts and overhead management time. With all this material is possible to propose a guiding conceptual framework for the educational and technological design that is going to be undertaken in this research. This guideline consists of four principles:

1. Collaboration is a skill that students need to learn and develop. This learning offers value to the employability profile of the student, to the development of lifelong transversal skills and as a useful tool to facilitate more learning.
2. Students develop a form of CoP when learning together, with emerging relationships with their peers, their environment and their learning goals. This communities can be nurtured, which in reciprocity generates a rich, heavily knitted and unique development, both as learners and professionals.
3. It is possible to aim for the ideal characteristics that help the development of collaborative attitudes and use them to design and develop learning tools that take advantage of a collaborative learning approach.
4. The advantages inherent to collaborative learning can be minimized or negated if proper attention is not given to the equally inherent problems that immediately arise. Any learning tool needs to be designed around these issues and provide resources for both the students and the educators to propose solutions fitted to their context and particularities.

This set of guidelines is meant to inform the design and development of learning objects, tools or experiences. Therefore, it is now necessary to analyse all the ideas so far exposed

about collaborative learning in the context of technology-enhanced learning, and particularly around augmented reality as a tool for education. With this approach, we will have all the theoretical foundations that inform this thesis, and this is the objective of the next section.

2.2 Augmented Reality in Technology Enhanced Learning

Throughout chapter 1, it was briefly explained how the interest in using [AR](#) as a tool for education is born from an inherent interest in the technology and a perceived value that the characteristics of [AR](#) could offer unique solutions to educational problems related to motivation, engagement and communication. It is now necessary to explore the current use of the technology in the education sector to identify advantages, disadvantages, common issues and, in general, the current state of the technology as related to the field of education.

2.2.1 Context

The idea of technology-mediated education has often been linked with that of collaborative learning. Lehtinen et al. (1999) highlight key ideas about the communication process developed in learning scenarios and how we use technology to facilitate and manage such activities. Many of the main concepts explored by the authors echo those already presented in the previous section. Ideas like the importance of nurturing a community, selecting proper tools for communication, structured process of review and mediation are explained in similar detail as before, as well as other common issues identified, like excessive competitiveness and factors for social friction.

Dillenbourg and Fischer (2007) propose some recommendations to incentivise effective collaboration in students, like physical spaces that facilitate interaction instead of individualisation, a common but flexible structure for collaboration that is transmitted to the students and techniques that the educator can use to orchestrate the technology used in classroom. It is key to acknowledge that the process needs constant moderation and motivation to create consistent results. These examples reinforce the idea that collaboration needs an extra effort to transform the work performed by teams into knowledge and learning. Coordination between the technology mediating the interactions and the expertise of the educator building the experience is crucial to achieve that goal.

Complementary, Kirkwood and Price (2014) offer a systematic review which aim is understanding what is being enhanced when talking about [TEL](#). When categorising the data, the authors found that interventions often sought changes in the current state of an educational material, and that the chosen technology could offer positive quantitative or qualitative changes, either in terms of markings, assessments results, motivation or deeper understanding of the teaching material.

The literature in the realm of [TEL](#) is rich and it is possible to identify some form of evolution in the topics analysed when following the jump from teaching machines (Watters, 2021) to computer-aided learning, to online and mobile learning. Among all the information that can be found it is easy to get lost or confused in all the definitions and terminologies proposed. A good example is the term Virtual Learning Environment ([VLE](#)), which will

often be used to describe the approach of this research. It tends to be used interchangeably with another concept, Learning Management System (LMS), which refer to the tools used in the administration of educational content and other administrative functions common of educative institutes, which is not the aim of this research. The term VLE is often abused a little to try and give more value to a system or set of tools more akin to an LMS.

To stablish more precise use of the term VLE, we can use the characteristics given by Warburton (2009) like immersion, a sense of presence, visualisation, contextualisation of content and simulation of impossible or dangerous experiences. It is interesting that the author also emphasises these elements:

- Tools for affective, empathic and motivational interactions.
- Intelligent interactions between individuals, communities and objects.
- Opportunities for individual and collective identity and role-play.

The emphasis on the social aspects of the interaction with any form of educative technology is crucial when analysing the enhancement provided by the tool in question. That emphasis can be summarized in three important elements: Visualisation of content, sense of presence and immersion, and a sense of collaboration or participation with other people.

With a a more precise definition of a VLE at hand and a set of tools to draw comparisons between technologies, in terms of visualisation, immersion, interaction and collaboration. The next question would be, why focus on AR? What makes AR an interesting technology for education? What makes it special or different enough from other technologies in the same spectrum, like VR?

AR saw a surge of popularity between 2011 to 2013 (Akçayır & Akçayır, 2017; Fidan & Tuncel, 2019) due to many factors like a wider adoption of suitable technologies for deployment. Successful implementation of applications in diverse scenarios has also been documented and reported (Javornik, 2016), and access to developer-focused tools like ARCore and ARToolkit prompted and facilitated development efforts. In general, and very similar to the case of VR some years prior, successful applications and explorative research was boosted thanks to new toolkits and technologies that facilitated learning and development.

In contrast to VR, the resources needed to develop and deploy an AR solution are less complex, and generally cheaper (Ivanova, 2018). This relative ease of development makes AR a popular technology to try out without the risk of committing too many resources into one single solution.

In terms of comparing the usage of AR with other similar technologies, different studies have shown numerous perceived advantages in the use of AR at different levels of education, and they are mostly consistent between studies: enhanced engagement in the learning activity, high levels of immersion and cost efficiency in terms of deployment and usage (Challenor & Ma, 2019; Chen et al., 2017; Saidin et al., 2015).

Common problems found are also consistent throughout literature and they are mostly related to usability issues: technology instability, steep learning curves and time-consuming usage. The term *cognitive overload* is also commonly found through the literature, normally associated to the unnecessary stress derived from the complications of using the technology in addition to the demands already present in the learning activity.

It is noticeable that most reported results are focused on validating the engagement of a particular development rather than its educational role in the learning activity and the educational objectives associated with the project in the first place. To broaden the analysis of why AR is a valuable technology for education, a complementary question can be asked: What educational goals are being fulfilled with the use of AR technologies?

The idea behind this question is to identify actual pros and cons of AR technologies through the lens of educational achievements rather than usability or feasibility, as is common in the current literature. To facilitate an answer, four supporting questions can be proposed:

- Are there other advantages or positive outcomes beyond a spike in the student's engagement?
- Are there circumstances in which AR technologies work better than other technologies?
- What are common practices and mistakes emerging from the reviewed literature?
- How do advantages, mistakes and general results change when the field of study or the educational level changes?

Given that AR is the main focus of this research, it was important to propose a deeper review of current literature in order to give substantial answers to the questions just proposed, and to position the technological development of this research in a proper educational basis that both uses well established educational practices and explores avenues, solutions and ideas missing or seldom touched by current literature. Sections 2.2.2 through 2.2.4 will then discuss in detail the systematic literature review performed for this purpose.

2.2.2 Systematic Literature Review Methodology

2.2.3 Analysis Phase

2.2.4 Discussion

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